Benchmarking Counterfactual Explanations of Model Change with Exact Ground Truth

Dinh Bao Bao, Tran Cong Minh and Le Hoai Bac

Faculty of Information Technology, University of Science
Vietnam National University, Ho Chi Minh City - Vietnam

Abstract. Without ground truth one cannot tell which method for explaining a model update sees which change. We contribute a benchmark with exact ground truth and a linear analysis of what five families of explanations can see, among them differential counterfactuals (Δ-CE): the nearest inputs on which exactly one model changes its decision by a margin. Used as a probe, Δ-CE stays silent on null updates of CNNs (no witness on 2 400 unfiltered queries, nor on 800 when it searches through a learned autoencoder; both registered), while counterfactual and attribution differences report a change. With two independent changes, witnesses point to the one near the query (registered). Gradient differences are blind to an offset and see a rotation, as predicted; a pre-registered hypothesis that Δ-CE recovers the changed factor better than they do was rejected. A margin score tells whether decisions moved; the witness adds a verified input showing where.

1 Introduction

An update that improves accuracy can still change individual decisions in unwanted ways [11]; explaining *how* the models differ is a goal of explainable AI under distributional change [3, 12], distinct from explaining a shift of the data [14]. Artelt et al. [1, 2] compare the counterfactuals [8] of one input under each model, or a difference of gradients; Muschalik et al. [4] compare feature importances; disagreement search [5, 6, 7] looks for inputs on which the models disagree. Ground-truth benchmarks exist for explaining one model [15, 16, 17], not a change, so what each family can see goes unchecked.

We ask which kind of change each family can see, and add *differential counterfactuals* (Δ-CE): the closest input on the data manifold at which only f_{new} changes its decision while f_{old} keeps it, both by a margin κ. Δ-CE anchors disagreement search at a query; unlike robust counterfactuals [9, 10], valid for both models, it seeks one valid for exactly one. We use it as a probe that should stay silent when nothing changed and otherwise return an input that can be checked.

Contributions. (i) A margin witness stays silent on null updates, also unfiltered and through a learned decoder, where counterfactual and attribution differences report change, and it localises two independent changes. (ii) A benchmark with exact ground truth: five rendered factors, changes of four shift types, null updates and a 4×4 grid over the rotation and threshold of the boundary. (iii) A linear analysis separating rotation from offset, tested on CNNs

and a ResNet-8 under a protocol fixed in advance, with registered follow-ups; all failures are reported.

2 Differential counterfactuals and what each family sees

Let $D : \mathcal{Z} \to \mathcal{X}$ map a search space onto the data manifold (here an exact renderer from factor space $\mathcal{Z} = [0,1]^5$). For class y the margin is $m(z) = f_y(D(z)) - f_{1-y}(D(z))$; m_o, m_n belong to f_{old}, f_{new}, and $h = m_n - m_o$. A query z_0 is valid if $m_o(z_0) \geq \kappa$ and $m_n(z_0) \geq \kappa$.

Definition 1. With $\mathcal{F}_\kappa^N = \{z : m_n(z) \leq -\kappa,\ m_o(z) \geq \kappa\}$, a Δ-CE of z_0 is $z^\star \in \arg\min_{z \in \mathcal{F}_\kappa^N} \|z - z_0\|$ if $\|z^\star - z_0\| \leq r$, and NOT_FOUND otherwise; swapping the models gives type O. Each $z \in \mathcal{F}_\kappa^N$ is a *witness*: two forward passes verify that the models decide differently, both decisively, which a difference of two counterfactuals does not.

Lemma 1. Every witness has $h(z) \leq -\kappa - m_o(z) \leq -2\kappa$. Hence models whose margins differ by less than 2κ everywhere have no witness. *Proof:* subtract the two constraints of $\mathcal{F}_\kappa^N$.

Corollary 1 (constant logit offset). If f_{new} adds b to the logit of class 1, e.g. the prior correction [13], then $h \equiv \pm b$ and $\nabla h \equiv 0$. Type-N witnesses exist only for the class whose margin b lowers and only if $|b| \geq 2\kappa$, at the points with $\kappa \leq m_o \leq |b| - \kappa$. *Proof:* insert $h \equiv -|b|$ in Lemma 1; no linearity is needed.

Linear case. For linear margins on $\mathbb{R}^p$ with independent w_o, w_n the nearest witness is unique (supplement). Write $\hat{w}_n = \cos\theta\, \hat{w}_o + \sin\theta\, v$ with $v \perp \hat{w}_o$, and let d_n, d_o be the distances from z_0 to $\{m_n = -\kappa\}$ and $\{m_o = \kappa\}$. The gradient difference of [1] is $-(\hat{w}_n - \hat{w}_o)$, counterfactual differencing $u_n - u_o$ (the two minimum-norm counterfactuals), the witness $u^\star$.

Proposition 2. (a) *Offset* ($\theta = 0$): the gradient difference is 0; counterfactual differencing is a multiple of $\hat{w}_o$; a witness exists iff $d_n \leq d_o$ and equals $-d_n \hat{w}_o$. (b) *Rotation* ($0 < \theta < \pi/2$): the gradient difference lies mainly along the new dependence v, the witness only if $\theta > \pi/4$ or $d_o(\sin\theta + \cos\theta) < d_n$; after projecting out $\hat{w}_o$ all three coincide up to scale. *Proof* of (a): both normals equal $\hat{w}_o$; of (b): supplement.

3 Benchmark and protocol

Data and models. Images are 32×32 ellipses rendered from five independent factors in $[0,1]$: aspect (task factor), size, colour, background and horizontal position; labels are $y = \mathbb{1}[\text{aspect} > 0.5]$ with 5% noise; the renderer is exact, so the factor change of any explanation is read without a learned oracle. All methods search the same factor space through the same renderer, so no method has access the others lack. f_{old} is a small CNN (five seeds); f_{new} is f_{old} fine-tuned on 10 000 samples from one condition (Table 1), as an update on shifted data would be; the shift is injected so that its effect is known. A pair enters only if its change is visible in decisions on validation data. For the grid we measure the

Table 1: Injected changes; $k^\star$: ground-truth factor. [a]$\alpha \in \{0, .1, .25, .5\} \times t \in \{.5, .53, .56, .6\}$, 2 seeds; 4 offsets tested. [b]Split D, 8 qualified; [c]split G; both registered.

Change	Shift	Adaptation data	$k^\star$	Pairs
Shortcut	spurious	colour correlated with label (0.99)	colour	3
Subgroup	local concept	labels flipped for size > 0.75	size	3
Threshold	concept	$y = \mathbb{1}[\text{aspect} > 0.6]$	aspect	3
Null	none / covariate	resample / size $\sim U[0.5, 1]$, same rule	—	5 / 3
Grid[a]	concept	$y = \mathbb{1}[\text{aspect} + \alpha(\text{colour} - 0.5) > t]$	aspect / colour	8 / 24
Offsets[b]	concept	grid, $\alpha = 0$, $t \in \{.53, .56, .6\}$, seeds 2–4	aspect	9
Both[c]	spurious + local	Shortcut and Subgroup at once	colour, size	8

Table 2: Recovery@r (found-rate), split A (locked), mean over three pairs (95% CIs within ± 0.035); last row: found-rate on the 8 null pairs.

	Δ-CE	CF-diff	Grad-diff	Imp-diff	Seg-search	No-prox	CF-new
Shortcut	0.38 (0.84)	0.54 (0.93)	**0.91** (1.0)	0.00	0.02 (0.08)	0.35 (0.63)	0.07 (0.93)
Subgroup	0.53 (0.81)	0.32 (0.99)	**0.62** (1.0)	0.00	0.06 (0.10)	0.29 (0.58)	0.30 (1.0)
Threshold	0.47 (0.47)	0.76 (0.90)	0.07 (1.0)	**1.00**	0.07 (0.08)	0.31 (0.40)	0.90 (0.90)
Null	**0.000**	0.994	1.0	1.0	0.000	0.000	0.996

realised rotation $\hat{\alpha}$ and threshold $\hat{t}$ of each f_{new} by a logistic fit to its decisions and analyse at these values.

Metrics and methods. Per pair: $N = 300$ valid test points. Recovery@r is the share of points with a valid explanation within the budget whose largest factor change is $k^\star$ (NOT_FOUND and ties count 0); it uses type-N witnesses only (pre-declared), so a query whose class the update raises counts 0. All counterfactual methods share one solver, the points and the budget $r = 0.54$, set once on validation. We compare Δ-CE ($\kappa = 0.5$) with **CF-diff**, counterfactual differencing [1]; **Grad-diff**, the gradient difference [1]; **Imp-diff**, a difference of permutation importances [4], one vector per pair; **Seg-search**, a line search towards training points, after [5]; **No-prox**, Δ-CE without proximity, the DeepXplore objective [6], to which DiG-IN [7] reduces on an exact manifold; **CF-new**, the counterfactual of f_{new}; and, in Section 4.4, IG- [18] and SHAP-differences [19].

Protocol. Each test split served at most one confirmatory test, after all choices were fixed (splits A–G in Table 3; dates in the supplement). The follow-ups on splits D, F and G were registered before their data existed [20]. Bootstrap intervals resample points within pairs, so Table 3 also counts pairs and the supplement repeats every test with the pair as unit; the rest is descriptive. A digit tier and a label-shift update failed qualification.

Table 3: Tests (95% CIs; †90%). Pairs: pairs on the claimed side / pairs; ‖point level only (≤ 4 pairs, pair-level $p \geq 0.0625$); the other confirmed rows also hold with the pair as unit (supplement). K: D = follows from a lemma or definition, R = risky prediction. When: pre = before any result, post = after the first (split B), grid = before the grid run, new = new data, reg = registered [20]. Holm families: *, ‡, §. ¶Run after its registered cost rule had excluded it. expl. = exploratory. Proj.: $\hat{w}_o$ projected out.

Claim	Data	Estimate	p	Pairs	Status	K, when
Abstention and where						
No witness on nulls	Null, B; Adult	0/2 400; 0/1 500		8/8; 5/5	confirmed	D, post; new
No witness on unfiltered nulls	Null, D	0/2 400		8/8	confirmed	R, reg
Same, search via VAE decoder	Null, F	0/800		8/8	confirmed	R, reg
No witness on nulls	ResNet-8, D¶; E, $\kappa^\star$	180/200; 0/200		0/2; 2/2	not; expl.	R, reg; new
CF-diff (no cut) flags $\lvert b\rvert < 2\kappa$	Logit offsets	0.961 [0.955, 0.967]	$2{\cdot}10^{-4}$ §		confirmed	D, new
Witness localises ($L > 0$)	Both, G	$L = 0.50$	0.004 (sign)	8/8	confirmed	R, reg
Offsets						
Grad-diff < 0.2	Grid, $\alpha = 0$	0.081 [0.066, 0.096]	$4{\cdot}10^{-4}$ ‡	4/4	confirmed‖	R, grid
Grad-diff < 0.2	Offsets, D	0.033–0.093	0.004 (sign)	8/8	confirmed	R, reg
Grad-diff offset-free	Grid	-0.098 [-0.143, -0.053]†	0.94 ‡		not conf.	R, grid
Δ-CE > Grad-diff	Threshold, B	$+0.31$ [0.27, 0.35]	$2{\cdot}10^{-4}$ *	3/3	confirmed‖	D, post
Rotations						
Grad-diff rises with α	Grid	$+0.57$ [0.53, 0.61]	$4{\cdot}10^{-4}$ ‡	$\rho = 0.89$	confirmed	R, grid
Proj. Δ-CE $\approx$ Grad-diff	Shortc. B; grid	-0.30; -0.35 (CIs ± 0.03)†	1 *; 1 ‡		not conf.	R, post; grid
Normal at $z^\star$ halves gap or more	Grid, new	$-0.19 \to +0.03$ [0.01, 0.05]†	$6{\cdot}10^{-4}$ §	4/4	confirmed‖	R, new
Δ-*CE versus gradient differences*						
Δ-CE > Grad-diff	Subgroup	-0.09 [-0.13, -0.05]		0/3	rejected	R, pre
Tie ($\lvert\Delta\rvert \leq 0.1$)	Shortc., Thresh.	$\lvert\Delta\rvert = 0.17$–$0.53$			not conf.	R, pre

4 Results

4.1 Abstention, detection and where

The witness stays silent when nothing changed. No disagreement search returns a point on a null update (Table 2). On the 8 null pairs, five null updates of an MLP on Adult, and 8 registered null pairs admitted without the original check (close to the witness criterion), no query has a witness, while CF-diff attributes a change to 97.7–100% of points; this includes the updates fine-tuned on covariate-shifted data. Silence does not need the exact renderer: searching through the decoder of an autoencoder trained on the images (registered; 100 queries per pair, on CPU, not GPU as registered), no null query has a witness (0/800; CF-diff 85–94%), while on 6 of 8 offsets witnesses exist for at least half of the lowered-class queries. The margin is what keeps the probe silent: with $\kappa = 0$ witnesses appear on 83% of null queries, and on offsets the witness rate rises from 0.02 to 1.00 with the largest margin change near the query (descriptive).

Silence costs little sensitivity, but a margin score tells *whether* as well. Each score is cut on the nulls to flag none (or 5%); we count flagged queries of the class an offset lowers. For a constant logit offset b, witnesses appear on every such query from $|b| = 1.1$ (Corollary 1), CF-diff flags ≤ 0.002 up to $|b| = 2$, the margin score $|h(z_0)|$ all from $|b| = 0.9$ at 5%. On the 8 registered fine-tuned offsets, at zero false positives, witnesses exist for 0.17–1.00 of these queries, the margin score flags 0.00–0.54 and CF-diff none. The witness beat the margin score by 0.2 in 7 of 8 pairs, not in all as registered, so we claim no advantage for *whether*.

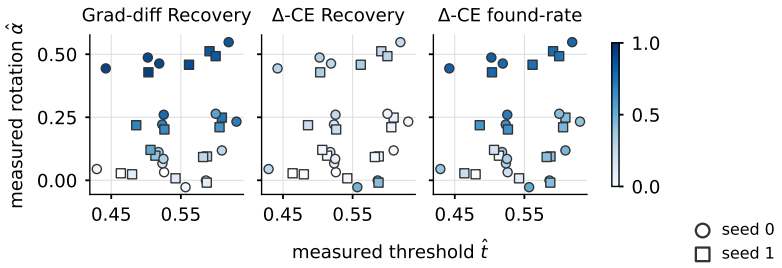


Fig. 1: Grid results at the measured rotation $\hat{\alpha}$ and threshold $\hat{t}$ of each f_{new}; colour scale 0–1; hollow: no $k^\star$; shape: seed of f_{old}.

Witnesses show where. In a registered update with two independent changes, a colour shortcut everywhere and a label flip for large objects, witnesses change size most for 46–75% of queries near the large-object region and for 13–23% far from it (difference $L > 0$ in 8 of 8 pairs, pooled 0.50, sign test $p = 0.004$). Grad-diff and CF-diff barely localise (0.09, 0.13), a global importance difference cannot; the counterfactual of f_{new} alone localises as well (0.51).

4.2 Offsets and rotations

Gradient differences are blind to an offset, as Proposition 2(a) predicts: their Recovery is 0.081 on the pure offsets of the grid and 0.03–0.09 on the 8 registered offsets (8 of 8 below 0.2; sign test $p = 0.004$). On Threshold Δ-CE beats them (0.41 vs. 0.10), in each of 3 pairs, too few for a pair-level test. Type-N witnesses exist only on the side the offset lowers (Threshold: class 1), hence 0.47 in Table 2; type O covers the other side.

Gradient differences see a rotation, increasingly with its angle: Grad-diff Recovery rises from 0.36 at $\alpha = 0.1$ to 0.93 at $\alpha = 0.5$ ($t = 0.5$) (Spearman $\rho = 0.89$ over the 24 pairs, permutation $p = 10^{-4}$; Fig. 1). The projection equivalence of Proposition 2(b) holds only with $\hat{w}_o$ taken at the witness (Table 3).

4.3 Attribution differences, other baselines, a second architecture

With predictions logged beforehand, IG- and SHAP-differences recover colour on Shortcut (0.93) like Grad-diff, and name aspect on Threshold (0.73–0.75 vs. 0.07), against the predicted blindness. The nulls show that this is no signal: there they name aspect on 57% and 71% of queries, and IG-diff on 42% of the registered nulls, as predicted. Imp-diff on test data ranks aspect first in all 9 change pairs, and $k^\star$ on adaptation data. Seg-search with ten times the segments finds witnesses for 0.26–0.47 of queries (predicted ≤ 0.2), none that Δ-CE misses.

A registered ResNet-8 replication shows that κ is model-specific: null fine-tuning moves its margins four times more and witnesses appear on 0.90 of null queries. Calibrating κ on validation nulls (rule fixed in advance; grid extended after $\kappa \leq 2$ failed) gives $\kappa^\star = 2.5$: then no new null query has a witness (0/200),

and witnesses exist for 0.78–1.00 of lowered-class offset queries. Recovery stays 0.36–0.40; Grad-diff is not offset-blind there (0.32–0.35).

5 Discussion and limitations

For *where*, the localisation test is direct evidence, but the counterfactual of f_{new} localises as well; specific to the witness is that it is verified and silent when nothing changed. **Limitations.** (1) The data are synthetic and binary; the learned decoder was tested for abstention and detection only; multi-class tasks, other domains, retraining from scratch and architecture changes are untested; the tabular test covers abstention only. (2) κ is in logit units, exact only for a constant offset, and must be calibrated on null updates of each model family. (3) Witnesses see only decisive changes on the manifold within the budget, without a certificate. (4) Several tests were formed after earlier results; changes were logged before their data existed, with two disclosed exceptions; supplement and code: github.com/Johnlrr/explaining-model-change.

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